CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BOAT CAPTAIN IN THE AI ERA

Self-driving boats are coming for the open ocean. The harbor, the dock and the passengers still need a captain.

★ TL;DR — Median ~$75K, with a 6–12 month road to a working credential. The catch: the credential is only half the gate — documented sea time is the other half, and it can't be rushed. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

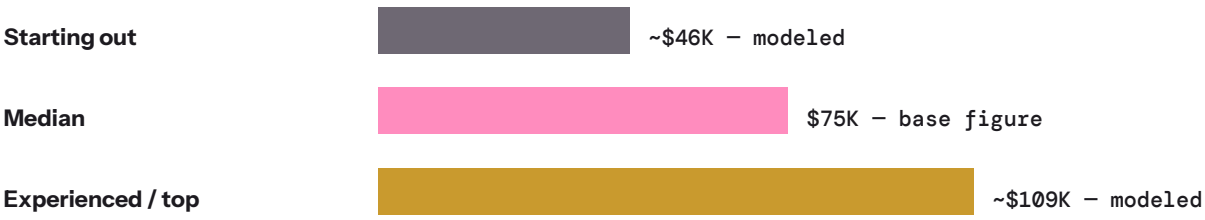
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- The credential plus logged hours on the water is the entry ticket.
- Pay splits hard: charter and tour captains live on seasons, commercial work pays steadier.
- Navigation software helps, but liability for the vessel and everyone aboard stays human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Boat Captain is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BOAT CAPTAIN ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Pilot the vessel: navigation, docking, anchoring, weather calls

- ✓ Run safety briefings and drills; own every emergency decision
- ✓ Manage crew, passengers and the trip schedule
- ✓ Inspect and maintain the vessel; log hours and incidents

Think: a bus driver, mechanic and emergency manager combined — where the road moves.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Chart plotters, autopilot, collision-avoidance alerts and booking platforms automate routine navigation and admin. Route-planning software keeps eating the paperwork side.	Docking in wind and current, reading real weather, handling a passenger emergency and being legally responsible for the boat — automation assists, the captain answers.

⚠ **Sea time can't be crammed: you need logged days on the water before the credential, and the best-paying work is seasonal in many regions.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Workdays on the water instead of in an office ✓ Charter tips and happy passengers on good days ✓ A clear ladder: bigger credential, bigger vessels	✗ Weather decides your income and your days off ✗ Weekends and holidays are peak charter time ✗ You're liable when anything goes wrong

Good fit? You love the water, stay calm when conditions change, and like being the final decision. Bad fit? You get seasick, hate early mornings, or want income that ignores the weather.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — CREW YOUR WAY UP	DOOR B — SCHOOL + YOUR OWN BOAT TIME
Start as deckhand or mate on tour boats, ferries or charters. You log sea time, learn local waters, and get carried through the credential process by employers who need licensed captains on their boats.	Take a captain's-license prep course, document your own boating hours, and pass the exams. Faster on paper, but you fund the boat time yourself and still need the logged days.

Smart move: Log every hour on the water from day one, with dates and vessel details — documented sea time is the currency every door accepts.

Where you land after: Larger-vessel credentials → tour or ferry captain → charter business owner or fleet operations.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
PICK YOUR	START LOGGING	TAKE THE	PASS EXAMS,	GET HIRED	UPGRADE THE

STEP 1 — Pick your water

FREE · TODAY

- Decide the arena: tours, fishing charters, ferries or private charters — each hires differently.
- Check the credential class required for the vessel size and passenger count you want.

STEP 2 — Start logging sea time

FREE · MONTHS

- Work as deckhand or mate, or log your own boating days with proper documentation.
- Examiners count documented days, not memories.

STEP 3 — Take the prep course

PAID · WEEKS-MONTHS

- License prep courses cover navigation rules, charting, safety and exam technique.
- First aid and CPR certification are standard requirements alongside.

STEP 4 — Pass exams, get the credential

WITHIN 6-12 MONTHS

- Pass the written exams plus medical and background screening.
- The entry credential (often called the six-pack) allows up to six paying passengers; a master credential covers larger work.

STEP 5 — Get hired or booked

FIRST SEASON

- Apply to tour, ferry and charter operators before the season opens.
- Build a reputation for safety and reliability — captains get rehired on both.

STEP 6 — Upgrade the credential

YEAR 1+

- Add tonnage and endorsements as your sea time grows.
- Bigger vessels and commercial routes are where the steadier money sits.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: choose your arena and read the credential requirements for it.

- Days 1–30: land a deckhand or mate spot, or start a formal sea-time log.
- Days 31–60: enroll in a prep course; book first aid and CPR.
- Days 61–90: sea time accumulating, coursework underway, exam date targeted.
- Day 90: pipeline set — the credential lands inside the 6–12 month band if the hours keep coming.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE HELM NEEDS A HUMAN. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.